

Case Study 12

The Zimbardo Prison Experiment

Philip Zimbardo was a tenured professor of psychology at Stanford University when he conducted his now famous Stanford Prison Experiment. In this experiment, 24 normal (as well as intelligent and moral) college students were randomly assigned to be "prisoners" or "guards" in a mock prison located in the basement of the psychology building at the university. The year was 1971.

In a relatively short period of time, the participants began quickly acting out their roles, with the guards becoming sadistic and the prisoners becoming passive and depressed. The experiment was originally planned to last two weeks but it was terminated after six days when a grad student, Christina Maslach, watching the experiment live (via video) from Zimbardo's office, became alarmed. (Christina, his then girlfriend, later married Zimbardo).



At the start of the experiment the “prisoners” were actually arrested by Palo Alto police and dropped off at the Stanford “jail”. They were then strip searched, sprayed for lice, and locked up with chains around their ankles. The “guards” were given authority to dictate 24-hour-a-day rules for the prisoners and were soon humiliating them in an effort to “break their will.”

What became evident as days passed was that the young men who played prisoners and guards revealed how specific circumstances can distort individual personalities. It appears that anyone, when given complete control over another, can act like a monster. "In a few days, the role dominated the person," Zimbardo recalled. "They *became* guards and prisoners." So disturbing was the transformation that Zimbardo agreed to end the experiment abruptly.

In contemporary society, this experiment would not be permitted. Zimbardo maintains, however, the participants suffered no long-term harm but admits that some had symptoms of mental breakdown during the experiment.

Related Incidences

Some psychologists compare the prisoner and guard transformations in Zimbardo's experiment to what happened to American soldiers when they abused prisoners from Abu Ghraib. Photographs released to the press showed previously average "churchgoing" people inflicting horrid abuse on Iraqi soldiers. More information on this scandal can be found by performing an Internet search with the key words "Abu Ghraib."